Once we had lodged our appeal, we agreed to go to Perth for the third Test. On the eve of the match the ICC had flown in Ranjan Madugalle, its senior match referee, in an attempt to defuse the simmering tension between the two teams. A meeting was staged between the two captains at the Hyatt Hotel in Ranjan's presence and Anil and Ricky shook hands for the cameras. In reality nothing had changed. The unpleasantness of Sydney would not go away and a number of issues remained to be straightened out at the WACA, where India had never won a Test.

The Perth Test turned out to be one of the best Test matches I was involved in. There is little doubt in my mind that the controversy had brought us together as a team. Sehwag was back and he gave us a quick start against Brett Lee, Mitchell Johnson, Shaun Tait and Stuart Clark on the first morning, helping us to win the first skirmish. He only scored 29 but it was enough to set the foundation for the middle order. Rahul and I then put together a very important partnership of 139.

It was in this innings that I had one of my toughest contests with Brett Lee. He bowled at real pace and I had to be at my best. I hadn't been in long when Lee bowled a fast bouncer. The shot I played still gives me a lot of satisfaction. I readied myself to play the upper cut over the slips, but then I realized that the ball was jagging back at me at furious pace. Within a fraction of a second the ball was just inches away from my head. I kept my eyes on the ball and was leaning back at almost 45 degrees when I finally met the ball with the bat right in front of my eyes. The ball flew over the wicketkeeper's head to the boundary. After that, I had a feeling it was going to be a good day. I went on to make 71 in our score of 330, with Dravid contributing 93.

Anil picked up his 600th Test wicket in Australia's first innings when he had Symonds caught by Rahul at slips. Anil's uncharacteristically exuberant celebration was an eye-opener for all of us and showed how much the wicket meant to the team after the Sydney Test. Breaking the partnership between Symonds and Gilchrist proved crucial. We went on to bowl Australia out for 212, with RP Singh taking four wickets, giving us a 118-run lead. We had set Australia a target of 413 and were beginning to scent victory. But there was still a job to be done and there was no room for complacency.

The final day was a classic piece of Test cricket. In fact, Ishant Sharma's spell of fast bowling that morning was one of the best spells by an Indian bowler in all my years of international cricket. Ponting and